

EVERY EXPERT WAS ONCE A BEGINNER



CLOUDINDEPTH.COM

STUDY NOTES

AWS SOLUTION

ARCHITECT ASSOCIATE



AWS Solutions Architect Exam Tips

This document provides 100 comprehensive tips for preparing and passing the AWS Certified Solutions Architect - Associate (SAA-C03) and Professional (SAP-C02) certification exams. The tips cover study strategies, technical concepts, and effective exam-taking techniques.

Table of Contents

1. Study Strategies
 2. Technical Concepts Focus
 3. Exam-Taking Techniques
-

1. Study Strategies

1. **Understand the Exam Guide:** Thoroughly review the official AWS Exam Guides for SAA-C03 and SAP-C02 to understand the exam format, content domains, and weighting. This is your blueprint for success. (Source: AWS Exam Guides)
2. **Hands-on Experience is Crucial:** Supplement theoretical knowledge with practical, hands-on experience using the AWS Free Tier account. Scenario-based questions often require a deep understanding of how services interact. (Source: Tutorials Dojo, AWS Exam Guides)
3. **Master the AWS Well-Architected Framework:** Both exams emphasize designing solutions based on the Well-Architected Framework (Operational Excellence, Security, Reliability, Performance Efficiency, Cost Optimization, and Sustainability). Understand its pillars and design principles. (Source: AWS Exam Guides, Tutorials Dojo)
4. **Read AWS Whitepapers and FAQs:** Don't overlook official documentation. Key whitepapers like the AWS Well-Architected Framework, AWS Security Best Practices, and FAQs for core services (EC2, S3, RDS, Lambda, VPC) are essential. (Source: Tutorials Dojo)

5. **Utilize Practice Tests:** Take multiple practice exams to identify weak areas, get comfortable with the exam format, and build stamina. Aim for 90% or higher on practice tests before the actual exam. (Source: Tutorials Dojo)
6. **Review Explanations Thoroughly:** For both correct and incorrect answers in practice tests, meticulously review the explanations and cited references to deepen your understanding. (Source: Tutorials Dojo)
7. **Create a Study Plan:** Develop a structured study plan, allocating sufficient time (e.g., 2 months for Associate, longer for Professional) to cover all topics. (Source: Medium articles)
8. **Take Detailed Notes:** As you study, take comprehensive notes. This active learning technique helps in retention and allows for quick review of key concepts. (Source: Medium articles)
9. **Compare and Summarize Services:** Actively compare similar AWS services (e.g., SQS vs. SNS, different database types, load balancers) to understand their specific use cases, strengths, and weaknesses. (Source: Tutorials Dojo)
10. **Focus on Scenario-Based Questions:** The majority of questions are scenario-based. Practice analyzing requirements (e.g.,

cost-effectiveness, high availability, fault tolerance, performance) and selecting the most appropriate AWS services. (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 11. **Identify Keywords:** Pay close attention to keywords in exam questions such as

“least expensive,” “most reliable,” “elastic,” “highly available,” “fault tolerant,” “serverless,” “managed,” and “low latency.” These keywords often point to the optimal solution. (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 12. **Understand Service Integration:** AWS is moving towards questions that mix multiple services. Understand how different AWS services integrate to form comprehensive solutions. (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 13. **Utilize AWS Exam Readiness Training:** Take advantage of free AWS Exam Readiness courses, which explore topic areas, map them to architecting on AWS, and review sample questions. (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 14. **Don't Guess Blindly (Associate):** For the Associate exam, there's no penalty for guessing on unscored questions. However, for scored questions, if unsure, eliminate incorrect options and make an educated guess. (Source: SAA-C03 Exam Guide, Medium articles) 15. **Reschedule if Not Confident:** If you're not feeling confident, reschedule the exam at least 48 hours in advance for free. An extra week of review can make a significant difference. (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 16. **Focus on Core Services:** While the Professional exam covers a vast array of services, both exams heavily feature core services like EC2,

S3, RDS, VPC, IAM, Lambda, DynamoDB, and CloudWatch. Ensure deep understanding of these. (Source: Exam Guides, Tutorials Dojo) 17. **Review In-Scope Services:** Pay close attention to the

in-scope services listed in the official exam guides for both Associate and Professional levels. (Source: AWS Exam Guides) 18. **Understand the Difference Between Associate and Professional:** The Professional exam is a leveled-up version of the Associate, requiring a deeper understanding of how services integrate and scale for complex organizational needs. (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 19. **Practice with Scenario-Based Questions (Professional):** The Professional exam heavily features complex scenario-based questions. Practice breaking down these scenarios to identify key requirements (e.g., high availability, cost optimization, security). (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 20. **Study Whitepapers for Professional Exam:** For the Professional exam, delve into whitepapers like

Securing Data at Rest with Encryption, Web Application Hosting in the AWS Cloud, Migrating AWS Resources to a New Region, and the Security Pillar of the Well-Architected Framework. (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 21. **Focus on AWS Organizations and Multi-Account Strategies (Professional):** Understand how to design and manage multi-account AWS environments using AWS Organizations, SCPs, IAM roles, and cross-account access. (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide, Tutorials Dojo) 22. **Deep Dive into Migration Strategies (Professional):** Familiarize yourself with various migration tools and approaches (e.g., AWS Application Migration Service, AWS Database Migration Service, AWS Snow Family, 7 Rs of migration). (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide, Tutorials Dojo) 23. **Understand CI/CD and Deployment Strategies (Professional):** Study Infrastructure as Code (IaC) with AWS CloudFormation, CI/CD pipelines (CodeCommit, CodeBuild, CodeDeploy, CodePipeline), and deployment strategies (blue/green, canary). (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide, Tutorials Dojo) 24. **Budget Your Time (Professional):** The Professional exam is long and challenging. Practice time management during mock tests, aiming for approximately 2 minutes per question. (Source: Medium articles) 25. **Don't Underestimate Networking (Professional):** A deep understanding of advanced networking concepts like Direct Connect, VPN, Transit Gateway, VPC peering, and hybrid DNS (Route 53 Resolver) is critical. (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide, Tutorials Dojo) 26. **Know Cost Optimization Tools:** Understand AWS cost management services like Cost Explorer, AWS Budgets, AWS Cost and Usage Report, and purchasing options (Reserved Instances, Savings Plans, Spot Instances). (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides) 27. **Understand Disaster Recovery (DR) Strategies:** Familiarize yourself with different DR approaches (backup and restore,

pilot light, warm standby, multi-site) and their associated RTO/RPO objectives. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides) 28. **Focus on Security Best Practices:** Implement the principle of least privilege, understand the AWS Shared Responsibility Model, and know how to secure data at rest and in transit using services like KMS and ACM. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides) 29. **Practice Eliminating Incorrect Options:** For multiple-choice and multiple-response questions, actively eliminate options that are clearly wrong or do not meet all the requirements of the scenario. (Source: Tutorials Dojo) 30. **Review Service Quotas and Limits:** Be aware of service quotas and how to design architectures that account for them, especially in high-scale scenarios. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)

2. Technical Concepts Focus

1. **IAM (Identity and Access Management):** Understand IAM users, groups, roles, policies (identity-based and resource-based), and the principle of least privilege. Know when to use IAM roles for cross-account access and service-to-service communication. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
2. **VPC (Virtual Private Cloud):** Master VPC concepts including subnets (public/private), route tables, network ACLs, security groups, NAT gateways/instances, VPC peering, and VPC endpoints. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
3. **S3 (Simple Storage Service):** Understand S3 storage classes (Standard, IA, One Zone-IA, Glacier, Deep Archive, Intelligent-Tiering), lifecycle policies, versioning, encryption (SSE-S3, SSE-KMS, SSE-C), and access control (bucket policies, ACLs). (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
4. **EC2 (Elastic Compute Cloud):** Know different EC2 instance types, purchasing options (On-Demand, Reserved Instances, Spot Instances, Savings Plans), Auto Scaling, Load Balancers (ALB, NLB, CLB), and placement groups. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
5. **RDS (Relational Database Service):** Understand different database engines, Multi-AZ deployments for high availability, Read Replicas for read scalability, and backup/restore strategies. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
6. **DynamoDB:** Focus on its NoSQL nature, primary keys (partition key, sort key), read/write capacity modes (on-demand, provisioned), global tables, and DynamoDB Streams. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)

7. **Lambda:** Understand serverless computing, event-driven architecture, triggers, concurrency, and integration with other AWS services (API Gateway, S3, DynamoDB). (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
8. **Route 53:** Master DNS concepts, routing policies (simple, weighted, latency, geolocation, failover, multivalue answer), and health checks. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
9. **CloudWatch:** Understand monitoring metrics, logs, alarms, and events. Know how to use CloudWatch for operational visibility and automated actions. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
10. **CloudFormation:** Learn Infrastructure as Code (IaC) principles, templates, stacks, and stack sets for deploying and managing AWS resources. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
11. **SQS (Simple Queue Service) & SNS (Simple Notification Service):** Differentiate between messaging services, their use cases, and how they enable loose coupling in architectures. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
12. **KMS (Key Management Service):** Understand encryption key management, customer master keys (CMKs), and integration with other AWS services for data encryption. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
13. **CloudFront:** Focus on CDN concepts, caching, origin access identity (OAI), and integration with S3 and other origins. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
14. **API Gateway:** Understand how to create, publish, maintain, monitor, and secure REST, HTTP, and WebSocket APIs. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
15. **Elastic Beanstalk:** Know its purpose for deploying and scaling web applications and services, and its supported platforms. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
16. **ECS (Elastic Container Service) & EKS (Elastic Kubernetes Service):** Understand containerization concepts, task definitions, services, and Fargate as a serverless option for containers. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
17. **AWS Organizations:** For Professional, understand OUs, SCPs, consolidated billing, and managing multiple AWS accounts. (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide)
18. **Direct Connect & VPN:** Understand hybrid connectivity options, their use cases, and differences in terms of bandwidth, latency, and security. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)

19. **AWS WAF & Shield:** Know how to protect web applications from common web exploits and DDoS attacks. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
20. **Storage Gateway:** Understand hybrid cloud storage solutions, connecting on-premises applications to AWS cloud storage. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
21. **DataSync:** Know its use for fast, online data transfer between on-premises storage and AWS storage services. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
22. **AWS Global Accelerator:** Understand how it improves availability and performance of applications by directing traffic to optimal endpoints globally. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
23. **AWS Systems Manager:** For Professional, understand its capabilities for operational insights, automation, and patch management across EC2 instances and on-premises servers. (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide)
24. **AWS Secrets Manager:** Know how to store, retrieve, and rotate database credentials, API keys, and other secrets securely. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
25. **AWS Config:** Understand how to assess, audit, and evaluate the configurations of your AWS resources. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
26. **AWS Trusted Advisor:** Know its role in providing recommendations for cost optimization, performance, security, fault tolerance, and service limits. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
27. **AWS Control Tower:** For Professional, understand its role in setting up and governing a secure, multi-account AWS environment. (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide)
28. **AWS Service Catalog:** For Professional, understand how to create and manage catalogs of IT services approved for use on AWS. (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide)
29. **AWS Data Pipeline:** Understand its use for automating the movement and transformation of data between different AWS data stores and on-premises sources. (Source: SAA-C03 Exam Guide)
30. **AWS Glue:** Know its purpose as a serverless data integration service for ETL (extract, transform, and load) operations. (Source: SAA-C03 Exam Guide)
31. **Amazon Athena:** Understand its use for interactive query service that makes it easy to analyze data directly in Amazon S3 using standard SQL. (Source: SAA-C03 Exam Guide)

32. **Amazon Kinesis:** Differentiate between Kinesis Data Streams, Kinesis Firehose, and Kinesis Analytics for real-time data processing. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
33. **Amazon EMR:** Understand its use for big data processing using frameworks like Apache Spark, Hadoop, and Presto. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
34. **Amazon Redshift:** Know its capabilities as a fully managed, petabyte-scale data warehouse service. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
35. **Amazon Aurora:** Understand its compatibility with MySQL and PostgreSQL, and its high performance and availability features. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
36. **Amazon DocumentDB:** Know its use as a document database service that is compatible with MongoDB. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
37. **Amazon Neptune:** Understand its purpose as a fully managed graph database service. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
38. **Amazon ElastiCache:** Differentiate between Memcached and Redis for in-memory caching. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
39. **AWS Backup:** Understand its centralized backup service for various AWS services. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
40. **AWS Snow Family:** Know its use cases for physical data transfer (Snowball, Snowball Edge, Snowmobile). (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
41. **AWS Transfer Family:** Understand its fully managed support for transferring files over SFTP, FTPS, and FTP directly into and out of Amazon S3. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
42. **AWS Client VPN:** Know its use for securely accessing AWS resources and on-premises networks from any location. (Source: SAA-C03 Exam Guide)
43. **AWS Site-to-Site VPN:** Understand its use for connecting your on-premises network to your Amazon VPC. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
44. **AWS Transit Gateway:** For Professional, understand its role in centralizing network connectivity across VPCs and on-premises networks. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
45. **AWS Security Hub:** For Professional, understand its role in aggregating, organizing, and prioritizing security alerts from various AWS services. (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide)

46. **AWS GuardDuty:** Know its purpose as a threat detection service that continuously monitors for malicious activity and unauthorized behavior. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
47. **Amazon Macie:** Understand its use for discovering, classifying, and protecting sensitive data in AWS. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
48. **AWS Certificate Manager (ACM):** Know its use for provisioning, managing, and deploying SSL/TLS certificates. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
49. **AWS CloudHSM:** Understand its use for dedicated hardware security modules (HSMs) within the AWS Cloud. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
50. **AWS Directory Service:** Know its purpose for connecting your AWS resources to an existing Microsoft Active Directory or setting up a new standalone directory. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)

3. Exam-Taking Techniques

1. **Read the Question Carefully:** Pay close attention to every word in the question, especially qualifiers like "most cost-effective," "highly available," "least operational overhead," or "secure." (Source: Tutorials Dojo)
2. **Identify Key Requirements:** Before looking at the answers, identify the core problem and all constraints or requirements mentioned in the scenario. (Source: Tutorials Dojo)
3. **Eliminate Distractors:** Many questions have plausible but incorrect answers (distractors). Eliminate options that don't meet all requirements or introduce unnecessary complexity. (Source: Tutorials Dojo)
4. **Process of Elimination:** Even if you don't immediately know the correct answer, eliminating one or two incorrect options significantly increases your chances of choosing the right one. (Source: AWS blog)
5. **Flag for Review:** If you're unsure about a question, make an educated guess and flag it for review if time permits at the end of the exam. (Source: Medium articles)
6. **Manage Your Time:** Keep an eye on the clock. Don't spend too much time on a single question. If stuck, make your best guess, flag it, and move on. (Source: Medium articles)
7. **Understand the Question Structure:** Be aware of multiple-choice (one correct answer) and multiple-response (two or more correct answers) question types.

(Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)

8. **No Penalty for Guessing:** AWS exams do not penalize for incorrect answers, so always choose an answer, even if it's a guess. (Source: Medium articles)
9. **Utilize the Exam Help Feature:** The exam interface often provides a help feature that lists short AWS service names and their full names. Use it if you encounter unfamiliar abbreviations. (Source: SAP-C02 Exam Guide)
10. **Focus on the "Why":** Understand not just what a service does, but why and when you would use it in a specific architectural context. (Source: General study advice)
11. **Think AWS Best Practices:** Always consider solutions that align with the AWS Well-Architected Framework and general AWS best practices. (Source: AWS Exam Guides)
12. **Prioritize Managed Services:** AWS often prefers solutions that leverage managed services to reduce operational overhead. (Source: Tutorials Dojo)
13. **Consider Cost Implications:** Many questions involve cost optimization. Always evaluate the cost-effectiveness of proposed solutions. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
14. **Think Scalability and High Availability:** Design solutions with scalability, high availability, and fault tolerance in mind, as these are core AWS principles. (Source: SAA-C03 & SAP-C02 Exam Guides)
15. **Security First:** Always prioritize security in your architectural decisions. (Source: AWS Well-Architected Framework)
16. **Read All Options Before Choosing:** Even if the first option seems correct, read all available choices. There might be a

better or more complete answer. (Source: General study advice) 97. **Stay Calm and Focused:** Exam anxiety can affect performance. Practice mindfulness or relaxation techniques to stay calm during the exam. (Source: General study advice) 98. **Review Flagged Questions:** If you have time at the end, go back and review all questions you flagged. Sometimes, other questions can provide context or trigger memory. (Source: General study advice) 99. **Don't Overthink Simple Questions:** Some questions might seem straightforward. Trust your knowledge and avoid overthinking, especially if you've studied well. (Source: General study advice) 100. **Celebrate Your Efforts:** Regardless of the outcome, acknowledge the hard work and dedication you put into preparing for the exam. (Source: General study advice)